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Scale armor, coat of mail

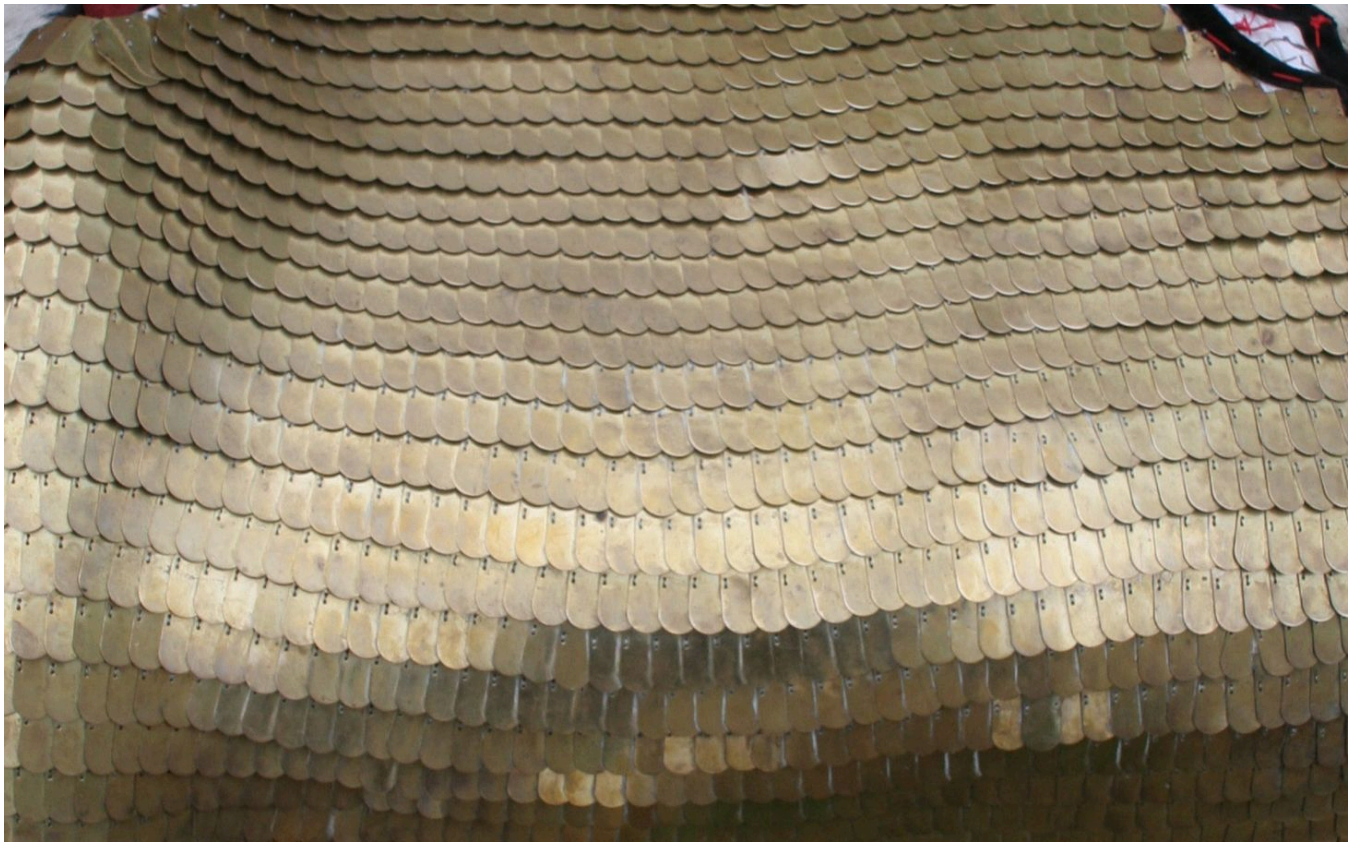
2.13 Scale armor, coat of mail

References:

Hebrew שִׁרְיוֹן, קַשְׂקַשָּׂת (shiryon, shiryon qasqasim) 1SA 17:5, 1SA 17:5, 1SA 17:38, 2CH 26:14, NEH 4:10

Greek ἁλυσιδωτός (halusidōtos) 1MA 6:35

Description and usage:



Detail of scale armor made of metal discs attached to each other (© MatthiasKabel, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)Scale armor was a kind of vest or shirt covering the upper part of the body. It was made of several hundred small bronze scales or platelets overlapping each other and sewn on a cloth or leather base. The scales were thin and about 11 by 6 centimeters (4.5 by 2.5 inches). Such armor was lighter than a solid metal breastplate (see 2.12 Breastplate, chest protector<REALIA:2.12>) and was also more flexible, giving greater maneuverability. It was used especially by a soldier who could not carry a shield but still needed protection in battle (for example, a chariot driver).

Translation:

Many languages will not have a specific term for such armor. In 1SA 17:5 both RSV and NRSV have the somewhat archaic term “coat of mail.” NIV has “scale armor,” and NCV says “coat of ... armor.” Where body armor is unknown, translators may say “shirt covered with thin metal plates to protect the chest.”

King Ahab was killed when a stray arrow penetrated some weak spot in his armor (1KI 22:34; 2CH 18:33). The Hebrew word used to refer to this weak spot in the armor is deveq. RSV renders it “scale armor,” but it seems more likely that the word refers to a joint between two parts of the armor. GNT has “between the joints of his armor,” and CEV says “where two pieces of his armor joined.”